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John Henry Newman and Bernard Lonergan: A Note on the Development of Christian Doctrine

PHILIP A. EGAN*

ABSTRACT: *The affinities between John Henry Newman and Bernard Lonergan have often been remarked, particularly the seminal influence of Newman's Grammar on the early Lonergan. Although Newman was only one tributary flowing into the mainstream, and so the 'chain of dependence' should not be over-estimated, Lonergan did remain in a two-fold debt to Newman: for his doctrine of assent and for his commitment to history. The manner in which Newman and Lonergan respectively tackle the vexed issue of the development of Christian doctrine is especially illustrative of this and illuminates many other subtle internal relations between them. The author briefly compares Newman's treatment of doctrine in his Essay on the Development of Christian Doctrine with that of Lonergan in Method in Theology. He then demonstrates that despite the significant differences, Newman and Lonergan actually inhabit genetically related horizons ('what Newman describes, Lonergan explains'). Their theologies of divine revelation are complimentary and they make a common commitment, each in their own way, to critical realism.*

KEY WORDS: *Assent; Church; Critical Realism; Development of doctrine; Differentiations of consciousness; Doctrine; Dogma; Genetically related horizons; Historicity; History; Intentionality analysis; Lonergan, Bernard (1904-1984); Newman, John Henry (1801-1890); Revelation; Self-awareness; Theology.*

RESUMO: *O artigo toma como ponto de partida a constatação de que é já quase um lugar comum assumir a existência de afinidades entre o pensamento de John Henry Newman e de Bernard Lonergan, particularmente no que se refere à influência matricial da obra Grammar of Assent de Newman no primeiro Lonergan. Contudo, apesar de Newman não ser mais do que uma corrente secundária a desembocar no processo global, de tal modo que de forma alguma se deve enfatizar em demasia a eventual "cadeia de dependência", a verdade é que Lonergan permaneceu numa dupla relação de dívida para com Newman, nomeadamente, em relação à sua doutrina do assentimento e ao seu compromisso com a história. Particularmente ilustrativo disto mesmo é o modo com que Newman e Lonergan, respectivamente, tomam nas mãos o difícil problema do desenvolvimento da doutrina cristã, o qual serve de modo especial para iluminar as relações intrínsecas existentes entre os dois pensadores. Nesse sentido, o autor do artigo compara sucintamente o tratamento que Newman dá à questão da doutrina no seu Essay on the Development of Christian Doctrine com aquele que*

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ao mesmo tema dá Lonergan em *Method in Theology*. Desta forma se demonstra que apesar de diferenças significativas, Newman e Lonergan habitam na realidade horizontes geneticamente relacionados, segundo a máxima de que aquilo que Newman descreve, Lonergan explica. Mais ainda, mostra-se também de que modo as suas respectivas teologias da revelação divina são complementares e representam um comum compromisso, cada um à sua maneira, com o realismo crítico.

PALAVRAS-CHAVE: *Análise intencional; Assentimento; Auto-consciência; Concreto; Desenvolvimento doutrinal; Diferenciações de consciência; Dogma; Doutrina; História; Historicidade; Horizontes geneticamente relacionados; Igreja; Lonergan, Bernard (1904-1984); Newman, John Henry (1801-1890); Realismo crítico; Revelação; Teologia.*

My fundamental mentor and guide has been John Henry Newman's *Grammar of Assent*. I read that in my third year philosophy (at least the analytic parts) about five times and found solutions for my problems. I was not at all satisfied with the philosophy that was being taught and found Newman's presentation to be something that fitted in with the way I knew things. It was from that kernel that I went on to different authors.¹

The seminal influence of John Henry Newman on the early Bernard Lonergan has often been remarked.² When in 1929 in his third year at

¹ LONERGAN, Bernard – "Reality, Myth, Symbol". In: CROKEN, Robert C. and DORAN, Robert M. (eds.) – *Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan. Volume 17. Philosophical and Theological Papers 1965-1980*. Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2004 (henceforth referred to as *CWL 17*), p. 388. Cf. LONERGAN, Bernard – "Insight Revisited". In: RYAN, William and TYRRELL, Bernard (eds.) – *A Second Collection. Papers by Bernard J. F. Lonergan S.J.* London: Darton, Longman and Todd, 1974/1996 (henceforth referred to as *A Second Collection*), p. 363. Also LONERGAN, Bernard – "Theories of Inquiry: Responses to a Symposium". In: *A Second Collection*. For background, see LAMBERT, Pierrot; TANSEY, Charlotte and GOING, Cathleen (eds.) – *Caring about Meaning: Patterns in the Life of Bernard Lonergan S.J.* Montreal: Thomas More Institute, 1982 (henceforth referred to as *Caring*) p.14. See also the unpublished *Dialogue Sessions* from the 1979 Lonergan Workshop at Boston College. This unpublished archival material is located in the Lonergan Research Institute at Boston College and will henceforth be referred to as *BC* followed by a file number, in this case, BC 79.8.2, p. 4.

² See EGAN, Philip – "Newman, Lonergan and Doctrinal Development". Diss., Birmingham, 2004 (unpublished). LIDDY, Richard – *Transforming Light: Intellectual Conversion in the Early Lonergan*. Collegeville: The Liturgical Press, 1993. Also, MATHEWS, William – *Lonergan's Quest: A Study of Desire in the Authoring of Insight*. Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2005, especially pp. 43-48. Others have explicitly devoted papers to aspects of Newman's thought and their influence on Lonergan. See, for instance: COULSON, John – "Front Line Theology: A Marginal Comment on Newman and Lonergan". In: CORCORAN, Patrick (ed.) – *Looking at Lonergan's Method*. Dublin: The Talbot Press, 1975, pp. 187-193. DESSAIN, Charles S. – "Cardinal Newman and Bernard J. F. Lonergan" (unpublished paper from the Lonergan Congress 1970). EGAN, Philip – "Lonergan on Newman's Conversion". In: *The Heythrop Journal*. 37 (1996), pp. 437-455. GALLAGHER, M. Paul – "Lonergan's Newman: Appropriated Affinities". In: *Gregorianum* 85 (2004), pp. 735-756. AMMOND, David – "The Influence of Newman's Doctrine of Assent on the Thought of Bernard Lonergan: A Genetic Study". In: *METHOD: Journal of Lonergan Studies* 7 (1989), pp. 95-115.

Heythrop, increasingly interested in epistemology,³ and increasingly sceptical about the philosophy he was being taught, Lonergan providentially took off the library shelf a copy of Newman's *Grammar*, it was an inspirational moment. Newman offered an alternative epistemological route, a route that started from attention to the actual operations of the human subject, a method and approach based on facts, lived experience and awareness of self. *Grammar*, as George Worgul put it in a suggestively titled essay 'The Ghost of Newman in the Lonergan Corpus', acted as Lonergan's "launch-pad".⁴ It led him to adopt the same approach as Newman, the method he would later call 'self-appropriation'. Shortly afterwards in 1929, Lonergan penned the *Third Blandyke Paper* 'True Judgement and Science'.⁵ Its original title revealed its focus 'The Illative Sense'. It was a study of Newman on the cognitional operations involved in reaching true judgement, and like Newman, Lonergan too rejected those who asserted logic and science to be the only criteria of certitude.⁶ Back in Canada in 1933, he wrote a more extended essay, over thirty thousand words long, on Newman's *Grammar*, but the essay has been almost entirely lost except for

HEFLING, Charles – "Newman on Apprehension Notional and Real". In: *METHOD: Journal of Lonergan Studies*. 14 (1996), pp. 55-84. MILLER, Edward J. – "The Role of Moral Dispositions in the Cognitional Theories of Newman and Lonergan". In: *Thought*. 67 (1992), pp. 128-147. STREETER, C. Mae – "The Lonergan Connection with Newman's *Grammar*". In: MAGILL, Gerard (ed.) – *Personality and Belief: Interdisciplinary Essays on John Henry Newman*. Lanham: University Press of America, 1994, pp. 173-183. WORGUL, George – "The Ghost of Newman in the Lonergan Corpus". In: *The Modern Schoolman*. 54 (1977), pp. 317-332. Note might also be taken of remarks *en passant* in MATTHEWS, William – "Lonergan's Apprenticeship 1904-46: The Education of Desire". In: LAWRENCE, Frederick (ed.) – *Lonergan Workshop*. 9 (1993), pp. 43-88 and especially pp. 58-64. Also, CAMPBELL, J. – "Insight and Understanding: The 'Common-Sense' Rhetoric of Bernard Lonergan". In: FARRELL, Thomas and SOUKUP, Paul (eds.) – *Communication and Lonergan: Common Ground for Forging the New Age*. Kansas MO: Sheed and Ward, 1993, pp. 3-22. Finally, Frederick Crowe has given extensive consideration to Newman's influence on Lonergan in his writings. See, for instance, CROWE, Frederick – *Outstanding Christian Thinkers Series: Lonergan*. London: Geoffrey Chapman, 1992, pp. 10-16. IDEM – "Bernard Lonergan's Thought on Ultimate Reality and Meaning". In: VERTIN, Michael (ed.) – *Frederick E. Crowe SJ: Appropriating the Lonergan*. Washington: The Catholic University of America Press, 1989, pp. 71-105. Also, – "The Relevance of Newman to Contemporary Theology". In: CROWE, Frederick – *Developing the Lonergan Legacy: Historical, Theoretical and Existential Themes*. Edited by M. Vertin. Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2004, pp. 213-227.

³ See remarks in a letter of 20 June 1927 written to a friend, Fr. Henry Smeaton, cited in LIDDY, Richard – *Transforming Light*, p. 32 footnote no. 56.

⁴ See WORGUL, George – "The Ghost of Newman in the Lonergan Corpus", p. 332.

⁵ LONERGAN, Bernard – "True Judgment and Science: A Paper read before the Phil. and Lit. Society Feb 3 1929". This unpublished *Third Blandyke Paper* is located in the archival material of The Lonergan Institute, Milltown Park, Dublin. It is, however, cited extensively in HAMMOND, David – "The Influence of Newman's Doctrine of Assent on the Thought of Bernard Lonergan: A Genetic Study".

⁶ For remarks on this, see LIDDY, Richard – *Transforming Light* p. 39f and MATHEWS, William – *Lonergan's Quest*, p. 45

a few pages.⁷ After that, however, Newman's name largely disappears from Lonergan's works, except for the occasional cameo appearance. Yet as anyone familiar with Lonergan who also knows Newman will aver, Newman is often anonymously on-stage or just in the wings. Indeed, he seemed to exercise a deep and abiding influence.

The nature of this early historical-biographical 'chain of dependence' of Lonergan on Newman, and then more importantly the long-lasting philosophical and theological influence of Newman on Lonergan, should not be over-estimated, despite the many affinities in their thought.⁸ Lonergan was a highly original thinker with very different ambitions. Moreover, his early intellectual *iter* ran from Newman through Dawson to Augustine, Plato and Aquinas. Although he would have been familiar with some of Newman's other writings besides the *Grammar*,⁹ Newman's influence was important yet only one of a number of tributaries flowing into the mainstream. In other words,

⁷ See HAMMOND, David – "The Influence of Newman's Doctrine of Assent on the Thought of Bernard Lonergan: A Genetic Study", p. 101f; also, GALLAGHER, M. Paul – "Lonergan's Newman: Appropriated Affinities", p. 740f. Also Richard Liddy's *Transforming Light* offers some useful quotations from Lonergan's Third Blandyke Paper (p. 39).

⁸ Michael Paul Gallagher identifies twelve themes in Newman found also in Lonergan's later thought: an awareness of the limitations of formal logic, the priority of the concrete, an attention to the performance of ordinary thinking in its journey towards truth, a knowledge of cognitional structure, the ability to learn from self-awareness, the validity of belief as a form of knowledge, the centrality of judgement, the distinction between religion and theology, the need for real assent in matters of religion, the key role accorded to conscience, the need to avoid a divorce between the intellectual and the moral, and the role of bias in preventing authentic self-transcendence. See M. Paul GALLAGHER – "Lonergan's Newman: Appropriated Affinities", especially his summary at the end, pp. 755-756. Others have remarked how even the most cursory reading of *Grammar* discloses many of the cognitional elements and themes that, percolating in Lonergan's mind, eventually surfaced in *Insight*. The resonances can at times be startling, such that *Grammar* has been called a veritable '*Insight-in-embryo*': see EGAN, Philip – "Lonergan on Newman's Conversion", p. 439. However, the argument here is that despite all this, the connections should not be pressed too far.

⁹ These included to a greater or lesser degree: *The Idea of a University*, *On The Present Position of Catholics*, *The Arians of the Fourth Century*, the *Oxford University Sermons*, the *Lectures on Justification*, the *Essay on the Development of Christian Doctrine* and the *Apologia*. Some of these works would have been standard catholic fare at the time. For Lonergan's acquaintance with *The Idea of a University*: see remarks by Richard LIDDY in *Transforming Light* p. 16 n. 1. Evidence of his early *en passant* knowledge of the *Oxford University Sermons*, *The Arians of the Fourth Century* and the *Lectures on Justification* rests on quotations within the third of the *Blandyke Papers*: see LONERGAN, Bernard – "True Judgment and Science", p. 4 (quoting Henri Bremond) and p. 6. See also the comments by HAMMOND, David – "The Influence of Newman's Doctrine of Assent", p. 111 n. 20. Later in life Lonergan became acquainted with Newman's *Essay on the Development of Christian Doctrine*: see remarks by CROWE, Frederick – "All My Work has been Introducing History into Catholic Theology' (Lonergan, March 28, 1980)". In: *Developing the Lonergan Legacy*, p. 96f. Lonergan himself acknowledged he had read the *Apologia*: see *Caring*, p. 15. Yet none of these other writings of Newman and their ideas made the same long-lasting impact upon Lonergan as the *Grammar of Assent*.

Lonergan's early thought as with his later, was shaped significantly by other authors. On the other hand, we should at the outset identify clearly what were the two most important and abiding influences of Newman on Lonergan: namely his doctrine of assent and his commitment to history.¹⁰

The first, Newman's doctrine of assent, has already been referred to. Briefly, Lonergan in that early *Third Blandyke Paper* took over Newman's distinction between assent and apprehension, asserting with Newman that true judgment is an act of the mind grasping by its 'illative sense' the virtually unconditioned from the convergence or cumulation of antecedent arguments and probabilities. Newman's description of apprehension and assent, and the operation of the illative sense, was exactly what Lonergan ever afterwards acknowledged as the inspiration for his own account of the third cognitional level, judgment.¹¹

The second influence, more general and more like a directional compass, was Newman's commitment to history.¹² From Lonergan's early essays on history, *The Analytical Concept of History* and the *Panton Anakephalaiosis*,¹³ through *Verbum* and *Insight* with their notion of the 'law of the Cross'¹⁴ to his later thought on historical consciousness, culture and the primacy of the fourth intentional level, moral consciousness, Newman, by bringing together history and theology, "continuously furthered", as Fred Lawrence once put it, Lonergan's own efforts in the same field.¹⁵ Moreover, Newman's *Essay on*

¹⁰ See EGAN, Philip – "Newman's Influence on Lonergan" (unpublished).

¹¹ In *Verbum*, Lonergan openly acknowledged how his account of cognitional Level Three, the reflective act of judgment, was indebted to Newman's doctrine of the illative sense. "[Here] the contention will be that the *intelligere* from which the judgment proceeds is a reflective and critical act of understanding not unlike the act of Newman's illative sense". See CROWE, Frederick and DORAN, Robert (eds.) – *Verbum: Word and Idea in Aquinas*. Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan, vol. 2. Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1997 – henceforth referred to as *CWL 2 Verbum* –, p. 60. See also LONERGAN, Bernard – "Insight Revisited". In: *A Second Collection*, p. 263 and p. 273. Also, *Caring*, p. 15. Also, the lecture Lonergan gave "Pope John's Intention". In: CROWE, Frederick (ed.) – *A Third Collection. Papers by Bernard J. F. Lonergan S.J.* London: Geoffrey Chapman, 1985 – henceforth referred to as *A Third Collection* –, p. 236.

¹² Crowe offers a brief account of Lonergan's interest in history and the various stages of its development. See CROWE, Frederick – "All My Work has been Introducing History into Catholic Theology".

¹³ For a brief account of the background to these essays, the connection with Christopher Dawson, and the order and dating of the essays archived in "File 713", see the masterly study by SHUTE, Michael – *The Origins of Lonergan's Notion of the Dialectic of History: A Study of Lonergan's Early Writings on History*. Lanham MD: University Press of America, 1993, especially pp. xiii-xxii and pp. 64-71. See also LIDDY, Richard – *Transforming Light*, pp. 74-90.

¹⁴ See LONERGAN, Bernard – "The Transition from a Classicist World-View to Historical-Mindedness" In: *A Second Collection*, p. 7.

¹⁵ Fred Lawrence suggests that Newman, in moving 'rhapsodically' beyond the logical control of meaning and value characteristic of classicism into a modern 'methodical' control of meaning

Development, Lonergan once opined, had opened up a new age in catholic theology, a theology that was historically conscious.¹⁶ When later in life he looked back on his career, Lonergan stated that all his work had been about “introducing history into Catholic theology”; the whole “problem in modern theology was the introduction of historical scholarship” and Vatican II was about coming to terms with this.¹⁷ That task of methodologically integrating history into theology, of course, was central to his *Method in Theology*.

When contrasting the common aspects of their thought, Lonergan often invoked the notion of differentiations of consciousness. He situated Newman variously within the commonsense and the transcendent differentiations,¹⁸ with himself in the methodical.¹⁹ Lonergan, however, was not consistent. It seems to this author that much of Newman’s work as an historian, a patristic scholar, a Christian apologist and litterateur would also fit well into what Lonergan understood by scholarship.²⁰

and value grounded in the data of consciousness, both anticipated and, more importantly, facilitated Lonergan’s own move in the same direction. For this discussion, and a fascinating application of the five transpositions Lonergan mentions in ‘The Future of Thomism’ (*A Second Collection*, pp. 43-54) to Newman’s thought, see Lawrence, FREDERICK – “Lonergan and Newman on Liberalism” (unpublished), pp. 4-8.

¹⁶ In a lecture Lonergan gave in 1973, he said that the new era in catholic theology dated not from 1965 when the Second Vatican Council closed, but rather from 1845 when Newman completed his *Essay on the Development of Christian Doctrine*. See LONERGAN, Bernard – “A New Pastoral Strategy”. In: *CWL 17*, pp. 237-238.

¹⁷ See CROWE, Frederick – “All My Work has been Introducing History into Catholic Theology’ (Lonergan, March 28, 1980)”, p. 78 and references.

¹⁸ For instance, speaking about his account of common-sense and theory, he said: “Thomas: he’s in the two. Augustine is just in the world of common-sense, a beautiful rhetorician; Newman too. They’re not technical people. They did tremendous work, but they are not technical in the way that Thomas was and Aristotle was”. Cf. LONERGAN, Bernard – “An Interview with Fr. Bernard Lonergan, S. J. edited by Philip McShane”. In: *A Second Collection*, p. 227. On another occasion, he said ‘Newman was not [...] systematic; it was spirituality’; in other words, Newman’s categories are not those of system but of religion. See *Caring*, p. 111.

¹⁹ Newman, Lonergan said, was a ‘creative genius’, but his language was ‘not systematic’; he ‘had not developed method to the same extent as me’. See *CWL 2: Verbum*, p. 17. Cf. *Method in Theology Institute, Dublin, 1972: Binder 2*, p. 542, response to Question 801 (unpublished papers at BC 71.4.1).

²⁰ Lonergan describes the scholar as one who has developed the skills of the linguist, the exegete, the historian. Unlike the natural scientist, the scholar does not aim at constructing a system, a set of universal principles and laws. He aims at coming to understand the common-sense of another time and place. The understanding he reaches is itself of the same style and manner as his own original common sense. But its content is not the content of his own common sense but rather the content of the common sense of some distant land or former time. Cf. LONERGAN, Bernard – *Method in Theology*. London: Darton, Longman, Todd, 1972 – henceforth referred to as *Method* –, p. 305

Doctrinal development

This now brings us to the focus of this paper. Whilst it would be true to say that both Newman and Lonergan, each in their own way, were absorbed with historical change and development, the thesis here is that the manner in which they tackle the vexed issue of the development of Christian doctrine is particularly illustrative and illuminative of the continuity and contrast between their thought. In a sense this is challenging, in that whilst doctrinal development was a topic Newman addressed frequently and explicitly in his writings, Lonergan dealt with it only occasionally and more implicitly. However, since it would be impossible in a paper to offer a fully exhaustive treatment of how Newman and Lonergan tackle this theme,²¹ we will restrict ourselves here mostly to Newman's *Essay on Development of Christian Doctrine* and Lonergan's *Method in Theology*.²² We will begin by discussing the aims

²¹ For a more thorough treatment of all the arguments presented here, see EGAN, Philip – "Newman, Lonergan and Doctrinal Development".

²² If we largely limit ourselves here to Newman's *Essay* and Lonergan's *Method*, we must nevertheless read these works within their wider context. Thus Newman's *Essay* needs to be seen within a broad swathe of selected other items from Newman's output, notably passages from *The Arians of the Fourth Century* (1833), *Lectures on the Prophetical Office of the Church Viewed Relatively to Romanism and Popular Protestantism* (1837), the *Oxford University Sermons* (published 1843, particularly 'xiii Implicit and Explicit Reason' and 'xv The Theory of Developments in Religious Doctrine'), the Newman-Perrone paper *De Catholici Dogmatis Evolutione* (1847), *The Idea of a University* (1859), *On Consulting the Faithful in Matters of Doctrine* (1859), *Apologia Pro Vita Sua* (1864), *An Essay in Aid of a Grammar of Assent* (1870) and the *Letter to the Duke of Norfolk on the Occasion of Mr. Gladstone's Recent Expostulation* (1875) and the revamped Preface to the *Third Edition of the Via Media* (1877). There are also suggestive passages in his *Letters and Diaries*, plus an 1868 *Unpublished Paper on Development of Doctrine*.

The topic of the development of doctrine is much more diffuse in Lonergan than in Newman. The two most relevant works are *The Way to Nicea* (the first part of his 1964 Latin theology treatise *De Deo Trino*) and more importantly *Method in Theology* Chapter Twelve "Doctrines", which represents the apogee of his mature thought on this topic. However, much of the Lonergan corpus, including *Insight* and the Cincinnati lectures *Topics in Education*, is apposite. In particular, several of Lonergan's papers and essays need to be considered: e.g. "The Assumption and Theology" and "Theology and Understanding" (in *Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan*. 4), and also "Method in Catholic Theology", "Time and Meaning", "Exegesis and Dogma" and "Theology as a Christian Phenomenon" (in *Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan*. 6. *Philosophical and Theological Papers 1958-1964*). The key period for this study is 1966-1972 and so a number of the papers in *A Second Collection* are pertinent, together with the 1971 Père Marquette Theology Lecture *Doctrinal Pluralism* (in *CWL* 7) penned about the same time as *Method* Chapter Twelve. In addition, from late Lonergan, one could take up *A Third Collection* and browse "Aquinas Today: Tradition and Innovation", "Healing and Creating in History", "Pope John's Intention" and "Unity and Plurality: The Coherence of Christian Truth". There are some other materials *ad rem* from outside these collections such as "Variations in Fundamental Theology" and the 1977 lecture "Philosophy and the Religious Phenomenon" (both in *CWL* 7). Finally, mention should be made of a weighty collection of secondary literature, although relatively scant

and contexts of Newman's *Essay* and Lonergan's *Method* and how they respectively handle 'doctrine'. We will then argue that despite significant differences of provenance, purpose and approach, their thought in fact evinces many subtle internal similarities. We will reduce these to three: the genetically related horizons they inhabit ('what Newman describes, Lonergan explains'), the complimentary theologies of divine revelation they espouse, and their common commitment to critical realism.

Let us first, then, consider the aims and contexts of Newman's *Essay* and Lonergan's *Method* and how they handle doctrine. Newman in the *Essay* was trying to rebut the charge that the Roman church of his day, compared with the church of the first few centuries, had invented new doctrines such as purgatory, the papacy and the immaculate conception of the Blessed Virgin Mary. In fact, all Christian communities, he averred, had undergone extensive development of doctrine, life and worship. The real issue was how to differentiate the genuine developments from the corruptions, and so Newman's aim was not, as it might be imagined, to open up future possibilities or to chart the infrastructure of how developments might emerge, but rather to demonstrate that those developments which had already taken place in the Roman Catholic Church by the mid-nineteenth century were authentic developments.

Lonergan's context in *Method*, on the other hand, was markedly different from Newman's: that of mid-twentieth century Roman Catholicism emerging from a 'dogmatic corner' in order to come to terms with history and so to undergo the *aggiornamento* called for by Pope John XXIII and the Second Vatican Council. The pressing issue for Lonergan was that of future possibilities: how to enable the church's tradition to enter into a critical and creative – and therefore progressive and developmental – 'conversation' with the modern world without losing its identity. In arguing for an approach that comprised both retrieval and engagement, Lonergan was endeavouring to develop an historically-conscious theological method that would enable catholic thought to enter into a critical dialogue with modern science, modern scholarship, modern philosophy and modern living.

It is interesting to compare Newman's understanding of doctrine with Lonergan's.²³ Newman held that the 'idea' of divine revelation and the 'impression' of its Divine Object, Jesus Christ, had been indelibly stamped on the

attention has been paid directly to this topic. There are three doctoral dissertations relevant, all at present unpublished: SMITH, F. – "The Permanence and Historicity of Dogma according to Bernard Lonergan S.J". (Rome: Pontificia Universitas Gregoriana, 1976), RILEY, P. Boo – "The Development of Doctrine: A Study in Bernard Lonergan's *Method in Theology*" (McMaster University, 1980) and EGAN, Philip – "Newman, Lonergan and Doctrinal Development".

²³ For a critical demonstration from the primary sources of the summary given here and of some of the challenges put to Newman's position, see EGAN, Philip – "Newman, Lonergan and Doctrinal Development", pp. 3-57.

heart, will, mind and imagination of the early church, immediately, as it were, on the apostles, but then, by divine guidance and inspiration, preserved henceforth in the bosom of the church. Revelation lives in the hearts, wills, minds and imaginations of believers and is authoritatively taught, and on occasion infallibly articulated, by the pope and bishops. This 'idea' for Newman, as Avery Dulles summarises, is at once "comprehensive, living and real".²⁴ It is comprehensive in that it is one unitary "master-vision",²⁵ diversely expressed in doctrine, life and worship. It is something alive, in that it takes hold of the mind, enters into relations with the ideas and opinions of its various socio-cultural contexts, and so in time can give birth to new dogmatic insights. It is something real, in that it is true absolutely, and whilst any human expression of divine mystery will necessarily have its limits, as a divinely given idea the human mind must submit to it. Interestingly, this idea, according to Newman, touches and influences heart and will before stimulating the intellect, and even then, Christian minds – reason ministering to faith – ruminate on it more unconsciously than consciously. The church, like Mary, ponders in her heart its meaning and its implications, and so aspects of the idea that implicit reason ruminates upon become explicit over time and even dogmatised, thanks to ongoing theological reflection and the counter-charge of heresy. Doctrine for Newman is thus an explicitation or expression in language of the inward idea; it is that which the church has always been and always will be implicitly aware of, although prayer, reflection and discussion is needed for the church to reach certainty about a doctrinal matter in a given historical context. She does this in a manner analogous to that of an individual engaged in any act of reasoning on a concrete practical matter. Through her 'ecclesial illative sense', the church thus discovers her mind, grasps the cumulation of evidences and, certain of her judgement, dogmatises the saving truth of revelation God has wished to communicate. For Newman, therefore, doctrine does not enlarge the idea itself but expresses an aspect of it, the church's 'newer' and later doctrines simply expressing further aspects of the one and only original idea.

Lonergan in *Method*, on the other hand, discusses doctrine and doctrinal development in relation to his intentionality analysis of the human subject, in this case as a 'product' of ecclesial life. For him, the driving force of any development in any discipline is the self-transcending subject as he or she attentively, intelligently, reasonably and responsibly seeks – and gives himself or herself to – that which is true, good and loving. The term and the fulfilment of this intentional drive is God's gift of his love, which for Christians,

²⁴ See DULLES, A. Cardinal – *John Henry Newman*. London: Continuum, 2002, pp. 69-76. See also DULLES, A. Cardinal – "From Images to Truth: Newman on Revelation and Faith". In: *Theological Studies*. 51 (1990), pp. 252-67.

²⁵ "Sermon xv". In: J. H. NEWMAN – *Fifteen Sermons Preached before the University of Oxford between 1826 and 1843*. London: Rivingtons, 1871 – henceforth referred to as *Sermon xv* –, p. 322.

Lonergan suggests, is the Word spoken inwardly in the heart through the Holy Spirit, and spoken outwardly in Jesus Christ and transmitted to us through the scriptures, traditions and fellowship of the Christian community.²⁶ Christians have the double task of reflecting on this Word – researching, interpreting, defining and defending it – and of mediating it “into the whole of human affairs”.²⁷ This double operation of retrieval from, and engagement with vastly differing geographical, historical and cultural contexts leads to both pluralism and development as the Christian community individually, locally and globally seeks to retrieve and express the gospel in terms meaningful to diverse contexts. Lonergan acknowledges the possibility of aberrant developments and conflict, depending on the presence or absence of three-fold conversion. Moreover, this is where dogmas and doctrines as definitive ecclesial statements of gospel truth have a normative function. Technically, doctrines for Lonergan are judgements, not in the sense of new conclusions from new insights but as statements of belief that express an ecclesial-personal commitment. They are derived from faith, the “knowledge born of religious love”, the reasons of the heart “that reason does not know”,²⁸ but in turn, they methodologically establish the normative horizon for theologians in their engagement with culture to reach new understandings by which they in their turn can guide pastors in creating more effective means of communicating the gospel. For Lonergan, the development of doctrine means principally a fuller, broader or more precise understanding of doctrine, not in the sense of a fuller understanding of data leading to the profession of new truths of faith, but in the sense of a fuller understanding of what is already a revealed truth of faith, albeit one now more effectively related to its context. The doctrinal differentiation within theology, Lonergan suggests, emerged at the time of the early church councils as the church sought to articulate the true and permanently valid meanings and values that should inform individual and collective Christian living. These dogmatic statements express “what God has revealed and the church has infallibly declared”, although “each is a product of its time and place, [meeting] the questions of the day for the people of the day”.²⁹ Believing his position to be consonant with Vatican I, Lonergan says that dogmas are permanently true yet historically conditioned. What is permanently true is their meaning within the context in which they were articulated; should the context change, as, for instance, with a differentiation of consciousness or through an attempted transposition to another geographical, histori-

²⁶ Cf. *Method*, p. 113. However, we will need to discuss further the methodological viewpoint that Lonergan adopts in *Method* in relation to his own theological, Christian and ecclesial commitments.

²⁷ LONERGAN, Bernard – “Theology in its New Context”. In: *A Second Collection*, p. 62.

²⁸ *Method*, p. 115.

²⁹ *Method*, p. 323 and p. 296, respectively.

cal or cultural milieu, then the dogma will need to be recast if it is to retain its meaning and value. This 'recasting' is the work of both individual theologians and of the whole church, and it involves the eightfold set of theological operations outlined in *Method*. For Lonergan, then, whilst doctrinal development can be stimulated by specific causes such as the challenge of heresy or, as with the Marian doctrines, further liturgical and devotional reflection and experience, development is brought about not by new revelations but by variations in the historico-cultural ecclesial subject. It is this differentiation of consciousness in the ecclesial subject which occasions the recasting and translation of doctrine – and thus the development of doctrine – as the church seeks to mediate the gospel into different contexts with their different needs.

Now, it would seem that the approaches to doctrine and doctrinal development that Newman and Lonergan espouse are largely incommensurable. Each sets out from a different starting-point and has a different purpose. One adopts a theological-historical, the other a philosophical-methodological approach. In effect, their accounts run along parallel trajectories. If for Newman, doctrine conveys, and indeed is identical in some sense with divine revelation, for Lonergan doctrines are treated as ecclesially constructed affirmations expressive of a faith-commitment. Both are concerned with the same 'thing', but like the difference between classical and modern biblical exegesis – one tending to view scripture as divine texts containing a human meaning, the other as human texts containing a divine meaning – they approach matters from different starting-points. Granted, Newman was not technical-systematic in the way Lonergan was. Newman was an historian, endeavouring theologically to interpret and explain church history, whereas Lonergan was a philosopher concerned with developing and applying a generalised method. Newman, moreover, wrote *Development* from a profoundly spiritual, apologetic and personal perspective; Lonergan, insofar as he wrote about doctrine and doctrinal development at all, at least in *Method* purposely adopted a theoretical, methodological and normative standpoint. Although Lonergan was deeply concerned with the fate of Roman Catholicism in an era of transition, doctrinal development was never a burning personal issue for him but an element to be explored in the general if long overdue transition going forward in Roman Catholic philosophy and theology.

Yet even if the accounts given by Newman and Lonergan appear to be incommensurable, closer inspection, it will be argued, suggests that there are many subtle internal interrelations and similarities. Let us explore three of them.

First, they inhabit genetically related horizons: what Newman describes, Lonergan explains. In other words, the inter-relationship between Newman's account of doctrine and doctrinal development and Lonergan's might neatly be captured by Lonergan's notion of 'genetically related horizons'. For Loner-

gan, all knowing takes place within an horizon of interest in which the data of experience (the facts) are found to be meaningful and valuable (related).³⁰ Horizons may differ and differences can be complimentary, dialectical or genetic. Genetically different horizons are related one to the other as

successive stages in some process of development. Each later stage presupposes earlier stages, partly to include them, and partly to transform them. Precisely because the stages are earlier and later, no two are simultaneous. They are parts, not of a single communal world, but of a single biography or of a single history.³¹

An example of a genetically related horizon would be the horizontal shift involved in moving between the different realms of meaning (commonsense [with its derivatives: aesthetics and scholarship], system, transcendence, interiority) or between differing stages or levels of development within a single, common process.³²

The difference between Newman's and Lonergan's accounts of doctrine and doctrinal development is not dialectical – the result of opposed cognitional theories, ethical stances and religious mentalities – but complimentary and largely genetic. In the first place, in *Insight* and elsewhere, Lonergan went beyond Newman's "very personal phenomenological investigation of experience"³³ to a critically grounded exploration of human subjectivity which supplies any theology of development with an explanatory account of human subjectivity (individual/collective) as the recipient of divine revelation. Thus Lonergan identifies what in effect is the 'spark-plug' of development, namely

³⁰ For a brief commentary on this, see SAUER, James – *A Commentary on Lonergan's Method in Theology*. Edited by P. Monette, and C. Jamieson. Lonergan Web-Site: 2000, pp. 238-240.

³¹ *Method*, p. 236.

³² James Sauer notes about the difference between the transition from Newtonian physics to relativity physics with its implicitly higher viewpoint would be a good example of such a shift as this:

Newtonian physics affirms that given knowledge of the antecedent conditions of a body (mass, velocity, position and force), one can determine the future position of that object. Relativity physics, on the other hand, argues that mass, velocity, and position are not absolute but relative. Thus, one can determine velocity and mass but not the position, or velocity and position and not mass. Developments of Newtonian physics were required for the development of relativity physics. Relativity physics is able to explain why and under what conditions the principles of Newtonian physics apply.

In other words, the difference between Newtonian and relativity physics is genetic in that it is traceable to the level of development. To calculate the movement of a billiard ball on a pool table, or build a bridge that won't fall down, we do not need to know relativity physics, but only the simpler formulae and calculations of Newtonian physics. However, to put a space ship on the moon, direct radio waves from satellites, or orbit telescopes around Mars, one cannot use Newtonian physics, one is obliged to use relativity physics. – SAUER, James – *A Commentary on Lonergan's Method in Theology*, p. 239.

³³ LASH, Nicholas – *Newman on Development: The Search for an Explanation in History*. London: Sheed and Ward, 1975, p. 47, citing Edward Sillem.

insight, within the 'motor', the cognitional and volitional operations involved in the human person's intentional thrust towards authenticity, truth, goodness and love. He moves beyond the commonsensical-scholarly to the foundational (theoretic-methodical).

In the second place, whilst Newman was one of the first theologians of the modern era to be thoroughly historically-conscious, it was Lonergan who went on methodically to correlate history and theology, devising the methodological framework for their systematic and critical inter-relationship. Lonergan's 'turn to the subject' had enabled him to achieve the higher methodical viewpoint.

And in the third place, although in his *Grammar* Newman acknowledged the need for a *novum organum investigandi*, it was Lonergan who actually developed the generalised method arguably able to bring the disparate specialisations of modern theology with all their inductive, deductive and discursive approaches into a single, internally coherent framework and unified approach. In other words, it was Lonergan who developed the possibility of making the shift from a descriptive to an explanatory framework.³⁴

Summing up, these three steps – from a theological-historical to a foundational perspective (philosophical-methodological), from a lower to a higher viewpoint, and from a descriptive to an explanatory framework – all suggest that Newman and Lonergan in their differing yet complimentary accounts of doctrine and doctrinal development inhabit genetically related horizons. Their accounts are correlated as earlier and later stages within the same trajectory. In a word, Lonergan explains what Newman describes. This is typical of the relationship between other aspects of their thought.

Secondly, Newman and Lonergan espouse complimentary theologies of revelation. This is, in a sense, a challenging statement to demonstrate, for Newman does not articulate a comprehensive or systematic theology of revelation and Lonergan's theology of revelation, as Neil Ormerod points out,

³⁴ In *Insight*, Lonergan said:

Description deals with things as related to us. Explanation deals with the same things as related among themselves. The two are not totally independent, for they deal with the same things and [...] description supplies, as it were, the tweezers by which we hold things while explanations are being discovered or verified, applied or revised. But despite their intimate connection, it remains that description and explanation envisage things in fundamentally different manners. The relations of things among themselves are, in general, a different field from the relations of things to us.

See LONERGAN, Bernard – *Insight: A Study of Human Understanding*. Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan, vol. 3, edited by Frederick Crowe and Robert Doran. Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2004 – henceforth referred to as *CWL 3 Insight* – p. 316. Lonergan adds that "the principle technique in effecting the transition from description to explanation is measurement" (*CWL 3 Insight*, p. 188). For an extensive discussion, see CRONIN, Brian – *Foundations of Philosophy: Lonergan's Cognitional Theory and Epistemology*. Nairobi: Consolata Institute of Philosophy Press, 1999, pp. 93-121.

is occluded and somewhat implicit.³⁵ Indeed, Newman's *Essay* has been criticised for its lack of systematisation, by which he at times treats revelation as personal, and at other times as propositional, with the result that his notion of revelation as an 'idea' becomes elusive and his correlation of doctrine with revelation ambiguous. Moreover, Newman's use of organic, logical and psychological images for doctrinal development in the 'Seven Notes' of the *Essay* has led some to believe that he is unwittingly proposing a real growth, intensification and expansion of the body of dogmatic knowledge – new revelations – rather than an explication of what is already there.

Lonergan's theology of revelation is hardly less vexing. In *Method*, he pre-scinds from a specifically theological discussion of doctrine and doctrinal development, because his purpose is otherwise. He examines this topic from the side of the human, historically developing, ecclesial subject, doctrines being normative expressions of the foundational stance of the theologian and his/her community. Nonetheless, it is possible to piece together elements of his implicit theological understanding of revelation.³⁶ He speaks of the Word, that is, divine meaning and value, entering into human history, and its communication across time and space into the full range of human cultures, affairs and contexts. This Word for Lonergan has both an inner and an outer dimension. The inner dimension is prior; it is the creative or uncovering moment, God flooding the heart with his love as a "vector, an undertow, a fateful call to a dreaded holiness".³⁷ The outer dimension of the Word is associated with the personal entry of God himself into history. Here, Lonergan's methodological approach stops short of theology, Christology, pneumatology and ecclesiology. He does not develop the Christian theology of revelation of the Word and Spirit required for a theological account of doctrinal development. But he does note in an aside that it is the personal entry of God himself into

³⁵ For Ormerod's thesis, see ORMEROD, Neil – *Method, Meaning and Revelation: The Meaning and Function of Revelation in Bernard Lonergan's Method in Theology*. Lanham MD: University of America Press, 2000, especially pp. 1-41 and p. 165.

³⁶ This theology is largely a matter of piecing together remarks such as this: "God becomes known to us in two ways: as the ground and end of the material universe; and as the one who speaks to us through Scripture and Tradition. The first manner might found a natural religion. The second adds revealed religion. For the first, one might say that the heavens show forth the glory of God; what can mere words add? But for the second, one must answer that, however trifling the uses to which words may be put, still they are the vehicles of meaning, and meaning is the stuff of man's making of man. So it is that a divine revelation is God's entry and his taking part in man's making of man. It is God's claim to have a say in the aims and purposes, the direction and development of human lives, human societies, human cultures, human history. [In this way] theology not only has to reflect on revelation but also it has somehow to mediate God's meaning into the whole of human affairs". – LONERGAN, Bernard – "Theology in its New Context". In: *A Second Collection*, pp. 61-62.

³⁷ *Method*, p. 113.

history that makes the Judaeo-Christian Word distinctive.³⁸ For the Christian the Divine Word reaches its fullness in Jesus Christ. This Word, as Fred Crowe puts it, is then “translated into human language through the pondering and reflection of prophet, evangelist, sacred writer”, transmitted through the divinely guided human agencies of the church, and guaranteed and authenticated “by the Holy Spirit present interiorly”.³⁹

Despite these different concerns and trajectories, the implicit-explicit revelation-theologies of Newman and Lonergan are inwardly complimentary. For Newman, doctrinal development is a God-given principle, because the original ‘idea’ in Christ has the potential to develop. Doctrine unfolds over time as the church engages with the vicissitudes of history. For Lonergan, the interior presence of the Spirit – the inner Word as prior – is critical to his (implicit) theology of revelation and (implicit) theory of doctrinal development, for it is this dynamic, pneumatic principle that inwardly inspires, directs and guarantees the mission of the church as she engages with history, authentically maintaining unity amidst diversity and preserving fidelity. For Lonergan, revelation is essentially and methodologically a loving power or dynamism and a liberative praxis before it is a dogmatic truth, whereas for Newman revelation is a divinely given knowledge, God’s truth, a series of doctrines to be expressed in action and holiness of life through a loving relationship with

³⁸ “The dynamic state of being in love has the character of a response. It is an answer to a divine initiative. The divine initiative is not just creation. It is not just God’s gift of his love. There is the personal entrance of God himself into history, a communication of God to his people, the advent of God’s word into the world of religious expression. Such was the religion of Israel. Such has been Christianity. Then not only the inner word which is God’s gift of his love but also the outer word of the religious tradition comes from God” (*Method*, p. 119). See also his note about *fides ex auditu* and *fides ex infusione* in: “Mission and the Spirit”. In: *A Third Collection*, p. 32.

³⁹ CROWE, Frederick – *Theology of the Christian Word: A Study in History*. New York: Paulist, 1978, p. 141. ‘Language’ here can mean more than spoken or written words and embrace all the various carriers of meaning Lonergan speaks of in *Method*, Chapter Three. Crowe does go on, however, to ventilate some of the difficulties theologians might have with Lonergan’s position: e.g. the apparent duality in God’s revealing activity and the implied relationship of the Spirit to the mind of Christ. Yet, he argues, ‘once we see the two-fold activity in God’s word... related to the two-fold sending of Son and Spirit’ then the key issue is really nothing other than why God should send both his Son and his Spirit as ‘two forms of God’s Word in the unity of one communication’ (p. 142). In the essay “Mission and the Spirit” Lonergan himself says that as the Father sent the Son, so the Son sent the disciples on a mission to continue to the end of time. As the Father and the Son sent the Spirit to the disciples, so they continue to bestow the Spirit on the ever oncoming members of Christ. So the self-communication of the Son and the Spirit proceeds through history by a communication that at once is cognitive, constitutive, and redemptive: it is cognitive, for it discloses in whom we are to believe; it is constitutive, for it crystallizes the inner gift of the love of God into overt Christian fellowship; it is redemptive, for it liberates human liberty from thralldom to sin, and it guides those it liberates to the kingdom of the Father. – LONERGAN, Bernard – “Mission and the Spirit”. In: *A Third Collection*, p. 32.

the Lord. Newman and Lonergan evidently share the same core theological, Christological and ecclesial commitments.

Indeed, we could go on to argue that Lonergan's methodical account of revelation 'fits underneath' Newman's account. The 'turn to the subject' that Lonergan espouses relieves the inner tension in Newman's account between the Word as personal and the Word as propositional truth by clarifying the otherwise ambiguous notion of the 'idea'. Moreover, he suggests a key role in doctrinal development for the Holy Spirit as interiorly present and refreshing the church. On the other hand, Newman goes beyond Lonergan's methodological concerns by supplying, particularly in his *Essay*, much of the theological, Christological and ecclesiological material, together with the history of its reception or rejection, that any systematic study of doctrinal development would require. He develops a quarry of what in effect are 'ideal-types' serviceable for systematic theology, that is models and theoretical constructs "in which possible events are intelligibly related to constitute an internally coherent system".⁴⁰ Finally, Newman has a strong account of 'implicit' knowing. This can act as something of a corrective to any apparent neglect or over-emphasis in Lonergan's account in *Insight* and *Method* on logical, formal and scientific knowing.

As we have said, neither Newman nor Lonergan offer a systematic account of doctrinal development. Yet taken together, their complementary theologies of revelation suggest a framework for such a theology. Because their views on revelation are arguably complementary, their approaches to doctrinal development are not entirely incommensurable, but proximate and inter-related. This again is typical of the relationship between them.

Thirdly, both Newman and Lonergan make the commitment to critical realism, though in different ways. For Newman, critical realism was – if this were possible – a theological commitment derived from the principle of the incarnation and only secondarily a philosophical commitment. Newman only tackled philosophical issues from within the context of apologetics – whereas for Lonergan, critical realism was essentially a philosophical commitment made on the basis of the knower's own self-affirmation.

For Newman, critical realism – not the terminology, but the conviction that human beings are capable of assenting with certainty to truth through

⁴⁰ Lonergan explores the function in history of ideal-types in *Method* pp. 227f. He speaks of their usefulness as both heuristic and expository [...] useful inasmuch as [they] suggest and help formulate hypotheses and [...] when a concrete situation approximates to the theoretical construct, [they] can guide an analysis of the situation and promote a clearer understanding of it. In so far as the [actual] historical situation satisfies the conditions of the ideal-type, the situation is illuminated. In so far as the historical situation does not satisfy the conditions of the ideal-type, it brings to light precise differences that otherwise might go unnoticed and it sets questions that otherwise might not be asked (p. 227).

the operation of the illative sense – was part of his grand struggle with ‘liberalism’. Liberalism for Newman was actually a *mélange* of positions, although fundamentally he defined it as the “anti-dogmatic principle and its developments”.⁴¹ Theologically, liberalism involved the rejection of truths which had been revealed by God or the submission of divinely revealed doctrines to the bar of human reason. Philosophically, liberalism for Newman was the exaltation of logic and scientific knowing over theological and all other forms of reasoning, the position that treats science alone as formally demonstrable, with other forms of knowing as ultimately mere opinion. Newman responded to these challenges both theologically and philosophically. Theologically, he insisted on the truth of revelation.⁴² Because doctrines for him were truths that God has revealed for our salvation, catholic dogma as a whole was “one, absolute, integral, indissoluble while the world lasts”⁴³ and had to be lived with conviction in a life that was holy. Philosophically, Newman who was influenced by Plato (imbibed from Augustine and the early church fathers), British empiricism, notably Joseph Butler, and (possibly) Coleridge, challenged liberalism’s reductionist epistemology. In his *Grammar of Assent*, he argued that whereas the empirical methodology of the natural sciences could lead only to probability, the certitude in knowledge we enjoy in the rest of our lives is a quality reached by the assent of the mind’s illative sense to the cumulation of probabilities⁴⁴:

Truth cannot change; what is once truth is always truth; and the human mind is made for truth, and so rests in truth, as it cannot rest in falsehood.⁴⁵

⁴¹ See NEWMAN, J. H. – *Apologia Pro Vita Sua: Being a History of His Religious Opinions* (2nd edition 1864). Reprinted and edited by Philip Hughes. New York: Doubleday, 1959, p. 48.

⁴² “If we believe in the revelation, we believe in what is revealed, in all that is revealed, however it may be brought home to us, by reasoning or in any other way. He who believes that Christ is the Truth, and that the Evangelists are truthful, believes all that He has said through them, though he has only read St. Matthew and has not read St. John. He who believes in the *depositum* of Revelation, believes in all the doctrines of the *depositum*; and since he cannot know them all at once, he knows some doctrines, and does not know others; he may know only the Creed, nay, perhaps only the chief portions of the Creed; but, whether he knows little or much, he has the intention of believing all that there is to believe whenever and as soon as it is brought home to him, if he believes in Revelation at all. All that he knows now as revealed, and all that he shall know, and all that there is to know, he embraces it all in his intention by one act of faith; otherwise, it is but an accident that he believes this or that, not because it is a revelation”: NEWMAN, J. H. – *An Essay in Aid of a Grammar of Assent*. Edited by Nicholas Lash. Notre Dame: University of Notre Dame Press, 1979 – the edition henceforth referred to here as *Grammar* – p. 152.

⁴³ *Sermon XV*, p. 317.

⁴⁴ “It is the cumulation of probabilities, independent of each other, arising out of the nature and circumstances of the particular case which is under review; probabilities too fine to avail separately, too subtle and circuitous to be convertible into syllogisms, too numerous and various for such conversion, even were they convertible”. *Grammar*, p. 288.

⁴⁵ *Grammar*, pp. 221-222. Newman continues: When then [the mind] once becomes possessed of a truth, what is to dispossess it? but this is to be certain; therefore once certitude, always

Loneragan was impressed with Newman's argument on the illative sense and saw in his appeal to the operations of the knowing subject a means of correcting the wrong turns of modern philosophy, especially its neglect of judgement. Indeed, Lonergan envisaged his own account of judgement – the need in humans “for an intellectual conversion *ex umbris et imaginibus in veritatem*”⁴⁶ – as overcoming two stubborn epistemological ‘myths’: that of idealism and that of naïve realism. This is the context for his discourse on doctrine in *Method in Theology*. Here Lonergan was concerned with demonstrating the normative function of doctrine within theology, and its permanent meaning despite historical variation and pluralism. In a lengthy discussion of the Vatican I dogmatic constitution *Dei Filius*, he hinted at his own theological world-view. Careful to avoid exceeding his methodological brief – the “exposition and defence” of church doctrines being “tasks not of a methodologist but of a theologian”⁴⁷ – he nevertheless suggests that his position in *Method* concurs exactly with what the Council had intended to affirm: that the meaning of dogma is permanent. On the other hand, this permanency is not opposed to the historicity of doctrine, since dogmas are statements, and statements have meaning only within their contexts.⁴⁸ But the essential point for Lonergan is this: the

permanence of the dogmas results from the fact that they express revealed mysteries. Their historicity [...] results from the fact that (1) statements have meanings only in their contexts and (2) contexts are ongoing and ongoing contexts are multiple.⁴⁹

In sum, because Newman and Lonergan espouse commensurable epistemologies, they also espouse commensurable (critically realistic) understandings of doctrine and dogma. They come at the same ‘thing’ but from different

certitude. If certitude in any matter be the termination of all doubt or fear about its truth, and an unconditional conscious adherence to it, it carries with it an inward assurance, strong though implicit, that it shall never fail. Indefectibility almost enters into its very idea, enters into it at least so far as this, that its failure, if of frequent occurrence, would prove that certitude was after all and in fact an impossible act, and that what looked like it was a mere extravagance of the intellect. Truth would still be truth, but the knowledge of it would be beyond us and unattainable. It is of great importance then to show, that, as a general rule, certitude does not fail; that failures of what was taken for certitude are the exception; that the intellect, which is made for truth, can attain truth, and, having attained it, can keep it, can recognize it, and preserve the recognition.

⁴⁶ LONERGAN, Bernard – “Cognitive Structure,” p. 219. In: LONERGAN, Bernard – *Collection*. Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan, vol. 4. Edited by Frederick Crowe and Robert Doran. Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1988.

⁴⁷ *Method*, p. 324.

⁴⁸ As he puts it: ‘dogmas are permanent in their meaning because they are not just data but expressions of truths, and indeed of truths that, were they not revealed by God, could not be known by man. Once they are revealed and believed, they can be better and better understood. But that ever better understanding is of a revealed truth and not of something else.’ *Method*, p. 325.

⁴⁹ *Method*, p. 326: cfr. his comments in *Method*, p. 323.

directions. For Newman, dogma is the expression of a divinely revealed truth which has to be received in faith as “one, absolute, integral, indissoluble while the world lasts”.⁵⁰ For Lonergan, these truths are ecclesial judgments, based on faith and expressive of commitment, which are permanently meaningful yet historically conditioned.

We also have here a classic instance of ‘what Newman describes, Lonergan explains’. Lonergan supplies the derivatively epistemological and metaphysical underpinnings that Newman’s account of cognitional process suggests. He offers an explanatory account of the relationship of insight, image and concept, and the role of agent intellect or understanding within the dynamism of the human mind in its natural orientation to truth, reality, being. As Fred Crowe puts it, he transcends the linguistic ambiguities of Newman’s account – the “troublesome” lack of a metaphysics – in favour of a “fuller view of cognitional structure, epistemology and ontology”.⁵¹ This classic shift in perspective demonstrates our earlier assertion that Lonergan has moved from commonsense to theory and from a lower to a genetically higher viewpoint. Thus whilst Newman’s response to the challenge of liberalism in matters of religion was principally theological rather than philosophical, Lonergan’s response to the errant turns of modern philosophy and its implications for theology was principally methodological and philosophical rather than theological. Yet in matters of doctrine, both envisage doctrine in the traditional sense as true: one as true because divinely revealed, the other as true because it is the outcome of a divinely graced ecclesial judgment. This accords with their common epistemological account of assent or judgement.

Concluding remarks

We have endeavoured to demonstrate how, when their interests overlap or coincide, Newman and Lonergan inhabit genetically related horizons, with complimentary theologies of revelation and the common epistemological context of critical realism. As a consequence, their views on doctrine and its development evince a ‘layered convergence’, one fitting ‘under’ the other so to

⁵⁰ *Sermon XV*, p. 317.

⁵¹ “[Newman] was the great pioneer in a view of how the human mind works when it is reaching out for truth – when it is learning, trying to form a correct judgment. Others have completed his work; the fuller view of cognitional structure, the epistemology and ontology that Newman lacked – all this has been supplied by Lonergan in his equally pioneering work, *Insight*. The dynamism of mind oriented to truth and being gives the basis of an epistemology; the distinction between understanding and concept shows why Newman was so concerned with images; the distinction of animal and human realism illuminates an obscurity in the relation of Newman’s image to reality, and so forth”. CROWE, Frederick – “The Responsibility of the Theologian and the Learning Church”. In: M. VERTIN (ed.) – *Frederick E. Crowe SJ: Appropriating the Lonergan Idea*, op. cit., p. 180.

speak. This typifies in many ways the overall relationship between Newman and Lonergan.

There was, as we noted at the outset, an historical 'chain of dependence' of Lonergan on Newman and so Lonergan developed insights and themes from Newman, particularly in relation to the illative sense and judgment, but also later in relation to history. Newman furnished Lonergan with a starting-point, an approach and an initial description – he supplied him with a directional compass – which he gradually elaborated into a comprehensive analysis of human intentionality. But Lonergan explains what Newman describes. He developed the themes that Newman identified and transposed them from a commonsensical or descriptive framework into a theoretic-systematic, and indeed methodical, account, sometimes contextualising them within the historical flow of classical and modern philosophy.

If we were to compare the *corpus* of Newman and Lonergan, then we could say that where Newman concerned himself with historical and theological matters, Lonergan generally concerned himself with matters philosophical and methodological, at least in the writings considered here. This is not, of course, to gainsay Newman's analysis of assent in the *Grammar* nor his analysis of human subjectivity in the *Essay* which he then applied to doctrinal development within the life of the church. But neither is this, on the other hand, to deny Lonergan's own critically important theological concerns, especially in his lectures in Rome, in the Latin theological works, and in his abiding interest in the contribution theology might make to the resolution of pressing human problems. Common theological, Christological and ecclesiological commitments are evident in both Newman and Lonergan, yet – to speak most generally about the *Essay* and *Method* – where Newman was absorbed with the Divine Object of revelation and how it makes an 'impression' on the human subject, Lonergan characteristically focused on the conditions of possibility of the human 'subject' being open to receiving that Word.

Finally, regarding Christian doctrine, Newman and Lonergan both view it in relation to assent or judgment as having a permanent value against the challenges of other approaches that tend either to relativise it (liberalism) or to ossify it (classicism). Both saw doctrinal development as ineluctably part of the church's historicity. For Newman, such development was a 'divinely willed' theological principle. For Lonergan, it was the result of personal, cultural and historical change giving rise to differentiations in consciousness. Furthermore, both, each in their own way, one ecclesologically, the other methodologically, contextualised the role of doctrine and its development within the wider spiritual, moral and intellectual life of the Christian, and within the wider devotional, theological and institutional life of the church.

To conclude. Anyone interested in Newman ought to be interested in Lonergan, and *vice versa*. Their thought can often evince a layered convergence,

not least because Lonergan found in Newman a crucial 'directional compass' for his own interest in judgment and in history. Their respective treatments of doctrinal development both illustrate this and disclose further subtle internal relations. Indeed, whilst respecting their unique historical contexts, specificities and distinctive concerns, there is a case for arguing that their thought on the development of Christian doctrine should be 'fitted together' and read as a kind of 'uni-duality', a simultaneously combined yet differentiated unity. Bringing them together in this way would immeasurably enrich the church's understanding of this sometimes baffling phenomenon. Neither Newman nor Lonergan offered a systematic theology of doctrinal development, although Newman approached such a theology more nearly than Lonergan. What we have found here would suggest that a layered convergence of Newman-Lonergan could precisely act as the starting-point, critical framework and 'steer' towards devising such a theology.